

2

MAJOR SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVES

SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVES

Before explaining theoretical perspective, it is necessary to introduce what perspective is?

What is perspective?

"A perspective is a broad assumption about society and social behavior that provides a point of view for the study of specific problems."

There are four of these general perspectives in modern sociology, evolutionary, functionalist, the conflict, and the interactionist perspectives. Most of the sociologists are guided in their work by a major *theoretical perspective*.

Ken Brown has given the example to understand the perspective. For example, imagine that there are five people looking at the same busy shopping street – a pickpocket, a police officer, a road sweeper, a shopper and the shopkeeper (see Fig. 1.1). The pickpocket sees wallets sticking out of pocket or bags, and an opportunity to steal. The police officer sees potential crime and disorder. The road sweeper litter and garbage left by everyone else. The shopper might see windows full of desirable consumer goods to buy, and the shopkeeper sees only potential customers. All are viewing the same street, but are looking at different aspects of that street. What they see will depend on their 'perspective' - what they are looking for. They might all be seeing different things, but you cannot really say any of their views is more correct than other – though you might think some views provide a more truthful, rounded and full description of the street than others do.

1. The Evolutionary Perspective

2. The Structure Functionalist Perspective

The basic principles of Structural Functionalism can be comprehended in three simple terms: maintenance of social stability, collective functioning, and social evolution.

Major assumptions of structural functionalism:

Assumption 1: Society is a combination of different parts (social institutions) like human body:

The functionalist perspective in sociology is a view of society that focuses on the way various parts of society have functions, or positive effects, that maintain the stability of the whole. The perspective draws its original inspiration from the work of Herbert Spencer and Emile Durkheim. Spencer compared societies to living organisms. Any organism has a **structure**—that is, a set of interrelated components, such as a head, limbs, a heart, and so on. Each of these parts has a **function**—that is, a positive consequence for the whole system, in this case a living organism.

Assumption 2: Each part of the society has some specific functions:

In the same way, Spencer argued, a society has a structure. Its interrelated parts are the social institutions *i.e.* family, religion, the military, and so on. Ideally, each of these components also has a function that contributes to the overall stability of the social system. Modern structural-functionalism (usually called function-alism) does not press the analogy between a society and an organism. But it does retain the same general idea of society as a system of interrelated parts.

Assumption 3: All parts of the system are interrelated and interdependent:

Each part of the society (social institutions) are interrelated and interdependent on each other in terms of their functional needs. And maintaining social order in society.

Assumption 4: Society tends to be organized and stable system:

Functionalist theory implies that society tends to be an organized, stable, well-integrated system, in which most members agree on basic values. Under normal conditions, all the elements in the social system—such as the schools, the family, and the state—tend to “fit together,” with each element helping to maintain overall stability and balance/equilibrium in the society.

Assumption 5: Slow and gradual social change is positive:

In the functionalist view, a society has an underlying tendency to be in equilibrium, or balance. Social change is therefore likely to be disruptive unless it takes place relatively slowly, because changes in one part of the system usually provoke changes elsewhere in the system. Sudden and rapid changes caused social disruption in society.

Main focus of the functionalist is on social order, stability and equilibrium in society.

They believe that whenever something becomes absolutely dysfunction, automatically removed by the society. If something exists in society, no matter how negative it is, it will definitely be functional for society.

3. The Conflict Perspective

According to Maccionis: "*Conflict perspective is a framework for building theory that sees society as an arena of inequality that generates conflict and change.*"

Assumption 1: Views of society that focuses on social processes of tension, competition, and change:

The *conflict perspective* in sociology is a view of society that focuses on social processes of tension, competition, and change. The perspective derives its inspiration from the work of Karl Marx, who saw the struggle between social classes as the "engine" of history and the main source of change.

Assumption 2: Assumes that societies are in a constant state of change, in which conflict is a permanent feature:

Conflict theorists assume that societies are in a constant state of change, in which conflict is a permanent feature. "Conflict" does not necessarily mean outright violence; it includes tension, hostility, competition, and disagreement over goals and values. This conflict is not an occasional event that disrupts the generally smooth workings of society: it is a continuing and inevitable part of social life.

Assumption 3: Conflict in the society has positive effect as well:

Conflict theorists do not see social conflict as necessarily destructive, although they admit that it may sometimes have that effect. They argue that conflict can often have positive results. It binds groups together as they pursue their own interests, and the conflict among competing groups focuses attention on social problems and leads to beneficial changes that might otherwise not have



occurred. In this way, social movements—such as those for women's rights or against nuclear power—become an important source of change. The changes caused by social conflict prevent society from stagnating.

Assumption 4: Society is composed of different groups competing for power and resources:

The conflict perspective views society as composed of different groups and interest competing for power and resources. ... The origins of the conflict perspective can be traced to the classic works of Karl Marx.

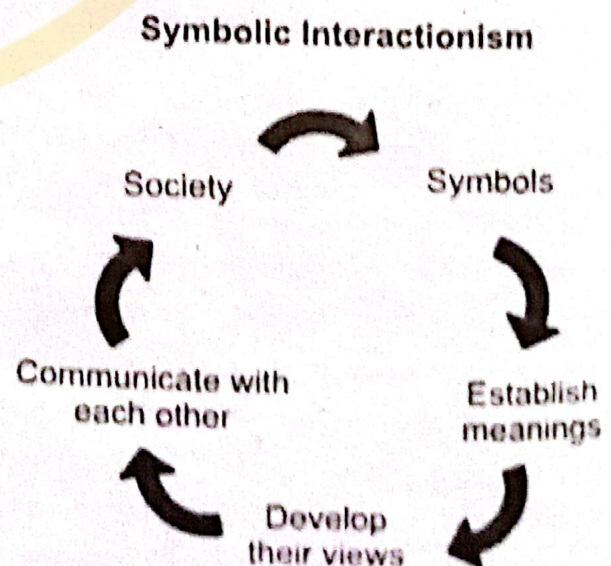
Assumption 5: There are two groups in the society- bourgeoisie (Haves) and proletariat (haves not):

Conflict, according to Marx, is between **bourgeoisie** — a wealthy and powerful group who owns and controls the means of production, and **proletariat**, — poor laborer who are exploited by the bourgeoisie. According to Marx, this conflict is between haves and haves not. Conflict between these two classes according to Marx, is a source of social change in society. This change will take place after the overthrow of the bourgeoisie by proletariat.

4. The symbolic interactionist perspective

According to Maccionis: *"Its broad focus on social structures that shapes society as a whole."*

The symbolic interactionist perspective, also known as symbolic interactionism, directs sociologists to consider the symbols and details of everyday life, what these symbols mean, and how people interact with each other. Although symbolic interactionism traces its origins to Max Weber's assertion that individuals act according to their interpretation of the meaning of their world, the American philosopher George H. Mead (1863–1931) introduced this perspective to American sociology in the 1920s.



Assumption 1: People attach meanings to symbols and verbal communication:

According to the symbolic interactionist perspective, people attach meanings to symbols, and then they act according to their subjective interpretation of these symbols. Verbal conversations, in which spoken words serve as the predominant symbols, make this subjective interpretation especially evident.

Assumption 2: Every word has specific meaning for senders and receiver:

The words have a certain meaning for the "sender," and, during effective communication, they hopefully have the same meaning for the "receiver." In other terms, words are not static "things"; they require intention and interpretation.

Assumptions 3: Conversation is an exchange of symbols between interacting individuals:

Conversation is an interaction of symbols between individuals who constantly interpret the world around them. Of course, anything can serve as a symbol as long as it refers to something beyond itself. Written music serves as an example. The black dots and lines become more than mere marks on the page; they refer to notes organized in such a way as to make musical sense. Thus, symbolic interactionists give serious thought to how people act, and then seek to determine what meanings individuals assign to their own actions and symbols, as well as to those of others.

Assumption 4: We learn the meaning of the symbol from the way we see others reacting to it.

Assumption 5: Once we learn the meanings of symbols, we base our behavior (interaction) on them.

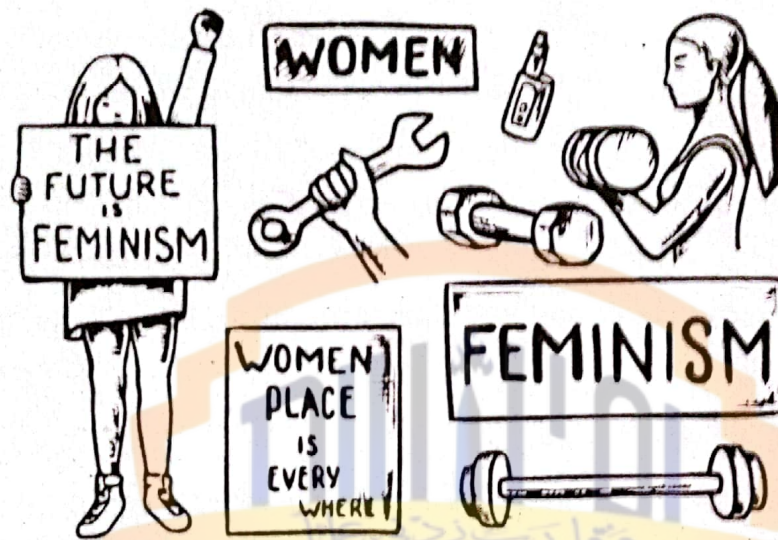
Assumption 6: We use the meaning of symbols to imagine how others will respond to our behavior.

MAJOR SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVES AT A GLANCE

	Functionalist	Conflict	Interactionist
View of Society	Stable, well integrated	Characterized by tension and struggle between groups	Active in influencing and affecting everyday social interaction
Level of Analysis Emphasized	Macro	Macro	Micro, as a way of understanding the larger macro phenomena
Key Concepts	Manifest functions Latent functions Dysfunctions	Inequality Capitalism Stratification	Symbols Nonverbal communication Face-to-face interaction
View of the Individual	People are socialized to perform societal functions	People are shaped by power, coercion, and authority	People manipulate symbols and create their social worlds through interaction
View of the Social Order	Maintained through cooperation and consensus	Maintained through force and coercion	Maintained by shared understanding of everyday behavior
View of Social Change	Predictable, reinforcing	Change takes place all the time and may have positive consequences	Reflected in people's social positions and their communications with others
Example	Public punishments reinforce the social order	Laws reinforce the positions of those in power	People respect laws or disobey them based on their own past experience
Proponents	Emile Durkheim Talcott Parsons Robert Merton	Hegel Karl Marx W.E.B. DuBois	George Herbert Mead Charles Horton Cooley Erving Goffman

5. Feminism

Feminism is a range of socio-political movements and ideologies that aim to define and establish the political, economic, personal, and social equality of the sexes. Feminism incorporates the position that societies prioritize the male point of view, and that women are treated unjustly within those societies. Efforts to change that include fighting against gender stereotypes and establishing educational, professional, and interpersonal opportunities and outcomes for women that are equal to those for men.



Feminist movements have campaigned and continue to campaign for women's rights, including the right to: vote, hold public office, work, earn equal pay, own property, receive education, enter contracts, have equal rights within marriage, and maternity leave. Feminists have also worked to ensure access to contraception, legal abortions and social integration, and to protect women and girls from rape, sexual harassment, and domestic violence. Changes in female dress standards and acceptable physical activities for females have often been part of feminist movements.

Some scholars consider feminist campaigns to be a main force behind major historical societal changes for women's rights, particularly in the West, where they are near-universally credited with achieving women's suffrage, gender-neutral language, reproductive rights for women (including access to contraceptives and abortion), and the right to enter into contracts and own property. Although feminist advocacy is, and has been, mainly focused on women's rights, some feminists argue for the inclusion of men's liberation within its aims, because they believe that men

are also harmed by traditional gender roles. Feminist theory, which emerged from feminist movements, aims to understand the nature of gender inequality by examining women's social roles and lived experience; feminist theorists have developed theories in a variety of disciplines in order to respond to issues concerning gender.

Numerous feminist movements and ideologies have developed over the years and represent different viewpoints and aims. Traditionally, since the 19th century, first-wave liberal feminism that sought political and legal equality through reforms within a liberal democratic framework was contrasted with labour-based proletarian women's movements that over time developed into socialist and Marxist feminism based on class struggle theory. Since the 1960s, both of these traditions are also contrasted with radical feminism that arose from the radical wing of second-wave feminism and that calls for a radical reordering of society to eliminate male supremacy; together liberal, socialist and radical feminism are sometimes called the "Big Three" schools of feminist thought.

Since the late 20th century, many newer forms of feminisms have emerged. Some forms of feminism have been criticized for taking into account only white, middle class, college-educated, heterosexual, or cisgender perspectives. These criticisms have led to the creation of ethnically specific or multicultural forms of feminism, such as black feminism and intersectional feminism.

Descriptive Questions

1. What do you mean by perspective? Also explain major assumptions of functionalist perspectives.
2. Write basic assumptions of major three sociological perspectives.
3. Draw a comparison between functional and conflict perspectives.
4. Write a note on Feminist school of thought.

Short Questions and Answers

1. What do you mean by theoretical perspective?

Ans.: A perspective is a broad assumption about society and social behavior that provides a point of view for the study of specific problems. There are four of these general perspectives in modern sociology, evolutionary, functionalist, the conflict, and the interactionist perspectives. Most of the sociologists are guided in their work by a major *theoretical perspective*.

2. Define structural functional perspective?

Ans.: According to Maccionis: *"Functionalist perspective is a framework for building theory that sees society as a complex system whose parts work together to promote solidarity and stability."*

The basic principles of Structural Functionalism can be comprehended in three simple terms: maintenance of social stability, collective functioning, and social evolution.

3. Explain major assumptions of functional perspectives?

Ans.: Assumption 1: Society is a combination of different parts (social institutions) like human body:

Assumption 2: each part of the society has some specific functions:

Assumption 3: all parts of the system are interrelated and interdependent:

Assumption 4: society tends to be organized and stable system:

Assumption 5: slow and gradual social change is positive

4. Define social conflict perspective.

Ans.: According to Maccionis: *"Conflict perspective is a framework for building theory that sees society as an arena of inequality that generates conflict and change."*

5. Explain major assumptions of social conflict perspective.

Ans.: Assumption 1: view of society that focuses on social processes of tension, competition, and change:

Assumption 2: assume that societies are in a constant state of change, in which conflict is a permanent feature:

Assumption 3: conflict in the society has positive effect as well:

Assumption 4: society is composed of different groups competing for power

and resources:

Assumption 5: there two groups in the society- bourgeoisie (Haves) and proletariat (haves not):

6. Define interactionist perspective?

Ans.: According to Maccionis: *"Its broad focus on social structures that shapes society as a whole."*

The symbolic interactionist perspective, also known as symbolic interactionism, directs sociologists to consider the symbols and details of everyday life, what these symbols mean, and how people interact with each other. Although symbolic interactionism traces its origins to Max Weber's assertion that individuals act according to their interpretation of the meaning of their world, the American philosopher George H. Mead (1863-1931) introduced this perspective to American sociology in the 1920s.

7. Explain major assumptions of symbolic interactionist perspective?

Ans.: Assumption 1: people attach meanings to symbols and verbal communication

Assumption 2: every word has specific meaning for senders and receiver

Assumptions 3: conversation is an exchange of symbols between interacting individuals:

Assumption 4: We learn the meaning of the symbol from the way we see others reacting to it

Assumption 5: Once we learn the meanings of symbols, we base our behavior (interaction) on them

Assumption 6: We use the meaning of symbols to imagine how others will respond to our behavior

8. Define feminism.

Ans.: **Feminism** is a range of socio-political movements and ideologies that aim to define and establish the political, economic, personal, and social equality of the sexes. Feminism incorporates the position that societies prioritize the male point of view, and that women are treated unjustly within those societies. Efforts to change that include fighting against gender stereotypes and establishing educational, professional, and interpersonal opportunities and outcomes for women that are equal to those for men.